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Rethinking queer migration through the body

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Discussions of the intranational migration of sexual dissidents have focused on rural-to-urban movement, and have largely conceptualized 'queer migration' through a symbolic rural–urban binary, consequently normalizing rural-to-urban displacement while eliding the real diversity of queer relocations. There is also a strong suggestion of teleological and ontological finality in the normalization of rural-to-urban relocation narratives, intimating a once-and-for-all emergence from the rural 'closet'. To elicit greater complexity, I suggest that the explanatory scale of queer migration should be downsized from fixed rural–urban contrasts to the actual movement of the queer body through space. To this end I rethink 'queer migration' as an 'embodied queer identity quest', suggesting that while 'coming out' often underpins relocation decisions, the personal, embodied *and* individualistic *nature of this experience generates movement on a variety of paths and scales. Arguably most important among these are peripatetic migrations, which most tellingly counter the teleology of rural-to-urban models. Moreover, in evoking embodied displacements predicated on 'coming out', I seek to contemplate the possible affects of bodily sexual desires in shaping the contours of queer migration.*

Key words: queer migration, rural–urban binary, body/embodiment, coming out, identity quest, peripatetic migration, sexual desire.

Sexuality and spatial displacement

In a recent editorial in *Society and Space*, Puar, Rushbrook and Schein (2003: 386) neatly encapsulate the issue underlying investigations of the migration of sexual dissidents: 'non-normative sexuality is often tantamount to spatial displacement'. That is, queer sexualities often appear 'out of place' in communities of origin, and are frequently only enabled by relocation elsewhere (Binnie 2004; Brown 2000). Hence, both academic research and anecdotal evidence suggest that while queers, like the wider population, migrate for education, employment and economic opportunities, these factors are *not* independent of motivations peculiar to their non-normative sexualities (Parker 1999; Weston 1995). While recognizing that sexual motivations dovetail with social and economic ones (Binnie 2004), for many queer migrants the quest for self-understanding and self-identity figure in the decision to migrate and the choice of destination. Yet the nature of queer migration—

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individual migrants' motivations and destinations, and paths, patterns and scales of relocation—remains little studied and inadequately conceptualized. As Binnie (2004: 90) recently notes, there is 'a need to conceptualize queer migration and to ponder why migration is significant to so many sexual dissidents'.

This paper takes up the call to (re)conceptualize queer migration, specifically *intranational* migration, by interrogating and integrating work from social/cultural geography, sociology, anthropology and history.[1] I suggest that current thinking on queer intranational migration has the potential to shut down debates on queer relocations, occluding the diversity and complexity of such displacements. Recent historical and empirical studies focus on rural-to-urban relocation, and typically conceptualize queer migration through a symbolic rural–urban binary, hence largely conflating queer migration with rural-to-urban displacement. Most problematic is the normalization of such thinking. Binnie (2004: 92), for instance, asserts that 'for lesbian and gay migrants within national borders, the primary shift is from rural to urban; provincial to metropolitan'. But this generalization is ironically drawn from work on a range of highly urbanized countries—particularly the USA (Chauncey 1994; D'Emilio 1983a, 1983b, 1989; Rubin 1993; Weston 1995), but also Brazil (Parker 1999) and the UK (Cant 1997)—and overlooks the commonsense assumption that most internal migration is actually urban-to-urban, thus eliding the real diversity of queer relocations. Moreover, the normalization of rural-to-urban movement is also theoretically problematic, intimating a once-and-for-all emergence from the rural 'closet', and hence presenting as teleological and ontologically final.

My contribution to these debates is *not* to replace these current frameworks *per se*—for they are significant in certain contexts—but to *add* another dimension, encouraging further discussion of queer relocations. To this end, this conceptual paper is organized as follows. In the first section I review studies of queer intranational migration, demonstrating how this work has normalized rural-to-urban relocation, and the consequent empirical and conceptual problems with this thinking. In the second section I provide an alternative perspective, detaching queer migration from rural–urban frameworks. I draw on—but critically rework and extend—Knopp's (2004) discussion of 'queer quests for identity' in order to rethink queer migration as an ongoing journey of personal self-discovery materialized in diverse paths and scales. This shifts explanatory power from the rural-to-urban scale of movement *per se* to the *embodied* motivations of individual migrants; from the fixed, symbolic contrast between the city and the country to the actual movement of the queer *body* through space. And since self-discovery and personal identity-formation is ongoing and fluid, never complete and fixed, a focus on embodied displacement also encourages us to question the teleology of rural-to-urban relocations, and enables us to contemplate *peripatetic* migrations by queers as progressive quests for sexual identity. But the body is not only a scale—it is the site of sexual identity-formation and the vector of movement. And so finally, in evoking the idea of embodied displacement, and given that *sex*uality plays an undeniable part in queer migration, I want to contemplate how bodily sexual desires might inform the (peripatetic) relocations of queer migrants.

This argument begins to create some productive linkages between cultural, queer and population geographies: it connects the demographic displacements of sexual dissidents with the prerogatives of non-heterosexual subjectivities by drawing on some key

ideas circulating in cultural geographies—notions of the body/embodiment, desire, and fluid, ongoing identity-construction. As a beginning, the argument is inquisitive and suggestive—a prompt for further conceptual and empirical work. Moreover, I have some preliminary explanations to make. First, I am using the term 'queer' in two ways. In one sense, queer denotes the multiplicity and diversity of non-heterosexual identities, and so I use queer as an 'umbrella term' to at-once speak of gay men, lesbians, bisexuals and other sexual dissidents. But simultaneously, queer signifies the fluidity and instability of sexualities, and since I conceive identity-formation as ongoing and incomplete, my deployment of queer also signals the way sexual identity and/or desire might shift back and forth over time between subject positions like gay/lesbian, bisexual and straight. Another clarification concerns the conceptualization of queer migration as an embodied identity quest, which might appear to romanticize the connection between dissident sexuality and spatial displacement. I do not intend to romanticize this link, or imply that migration always underpins sexual self-actualization (see Schimel 1997, for instance). Rather, the following discussion attempts to conceptualize the imperatives and outcomes of migration for those queers who do choose to move—and moreover, move for reasons at least partly predicated on sexual identity and desire.

Reviewing rural–urban conceptualizations of queer migration

The historical and empirical literature

The idea of the rural–urban binary is the key framework through which queer intranational migration has been conceptualized, partly due to historical reasons (Binnie 2004). Rubin (1993), Chauncey (1994) and D'Emilio (1983a, 1983b, 1989) all argue that late-nineteenth/early-twentieth century (*fin de siécle*) industrialization and urbanization in North America and Europe facilitated the migration of sexual dissidents from rural areas to urban centres. While the same-sex-attracted were not exclusively subject to these social forces, the development of urban-industrial labour markets—which spurred urbanization—was particularly important for the formation of queer communities and self-consciousness. For instance, Rubin contends that this swell of single men and women in rapidly growing cities provided the basis for urban queer communities to form:

> The relocation of homoeroticism into these quasi-ethnic, nucleated, sexually constituted communities is to some extent a consequence of the transfers of population brought about by industrialization. As laborers migrated to work in cities, there were increased opportunities for voluntary communities to form. Homosexually inclined women and men, who would have been vulnerable and isolated in most pre-industrial villages, began to congregate in small corners of the big cities. (1993: 17)

Consequently, queer subjects came to discursively perceive and to materially construct various urban centres and settings as 'homelands' (Stychin 2000). Moreover, as a result of these social forces, queer consciousness was spatialized, with the urban naturalized as 'a beacon of tolerance and gay community, the country a locus of persecution and gay absence' (Weston 1995: 262). Rural-to-urban migration became central to this imaginary: since 'gay identity [was] first and foremost an urban identity' (Binnie 2004: 91), same-sex-attracted subjects often relocated from the

perceived constraints of *rural isolation* to the imagined and real freedoms and opportunities of the *urban community* (Spurlin 2000). Hence, Binnie (2004) argues that the rural–urban distinction became embedded in queer consciousness, and that rural-to-urban migration enabled self-actualization.

Perhaps as a consequence of these historical studies, recent empirical work has focused on the rural-to-urban movement of queers. In widely differing cultural and economic contexts, Weston (1995), Cant (1997) and Parker (1999) emphasize the role of the rural–urban dichotomy in queer migration and self-actualization. All three studies highlight a prominent *uni*-directional outflow of queers from rural areas, small towns and provincial centres, and into larger metropolitan hubs. Weston's study of the USA's 'great gay migration' of the 1970s and 1980s, where thousands of American queers moved to San Francisco, perhaps most clearly interprets queer migration through a rural–urban framework. In 'Get thee to a big city', Weston (1995: 255, 274) contends that 'the gay imaginary is not just a dream of freedom to "be gay" that requires an urban location, but a symbolic space that configures gayness itself by elaborating an opposition between rural and urban life', suggesting that 'this symbolic contrast was central to the organization of many coming out stories'. Even urban-to-urban and intra-city movements are largely interpreted through rural–urban symbolism:

> City dwellers' descriptions of learning how to get downtown on the bus in order to find a lesbian bar or a gay male cruising area incorporate all the standard elements of risk, dislocation, and naiveté found in chronicles of rural–urban migration. … In their very departures from the conventional narrative of gay migration, these counterexamples illustrate the ways that rural/urban contrasts are bound up with the creation of an imagined community peopled by gay subjects. (Weston 1995: 268–269)

The assertion that rural–urban contrasts are implicated in the way queer subjects *generally* make sense of their relocations moves towards normalizing queer migration as rural-to-urban displacement. Similarly, rural–urban contrasts underpin Parker's (1999: 187) explanation of the relocation of gay men in Brazil during the 1980s and 1990s, where the perceived 'alternative homosexual freedom of urban life' was a crucial factor for most in the decision to migrate. And while Cant's (1997: 8–9) discussion of queer migration in the UK allows for more complexity, he also points to the importance, for many, of a palpable discursive opposition between rural—regional communities and the cosmopolitan possibilities of London, Manchester and Brighton.

Yet I do not wish to take serious issue with the work of Weston, Parker or Cant in itself. Their studies largely concentrate on rural-to-urban movers, so it is not surprising that in their analyses a symbolic rural–urban contrast underpins relocation, the organization of coming out narratives and sexual self-actualization. Rather, I survey their work to underscore how recent studies have overwhelmingly—indeed, singularly—focused on rural-to-urban displacement. It is this narrow perspective with which I take issue. Weston and Parker, in particular, appear to include urban-to-urban movements as *counter*examples—considering such migration in light of rural-to-urban movements, not as a discrete phenomenon—and channel their explanations for such displacement *through* rural–urban frameworks. In this way, rural-to-urban movement begins to be seen as the *foremost* and *archetypal* trajectory of queer displacement, and other moves, like those between cities, are understood as not merely additional,

but as *fundamentally similar* to moving from rural areas to cities, and hence not requiring further explanation or analysis.

This, in turn, draws attention to a serious empirical-cum-conceptual problem with these studies. The focus on rural-to-urban relocation elides the fact that in the late-twentieth century context of these studies, the USA, the UK and Brazil are all highly urbanized countries, each with over 80 per cent of their national populations resident in variously defined urban areas.[2] In this situation—and in contrast to the context of *fin de siécle* urbanization underpinning earlier historical analyses by Rubin, Chauncey and D'Emilio—the greater part of internal migration is consequently urban-to-urban. The 'city-hopper' is the norm, while the rural out-mover is actually in the minority, and this is as likely to be true for queer migrants as for the rest of the population.[3] I do not make this claim in order to deny the reality of rural-to-urban queer migration, nor do I seek to assert the importance of urban-to-urban movement above other displacements, and thus replace the focus on rural out-movers with one on urban-to-urban migrants. Rather, I suggest that the assumption that the predominant and conceptually grounding trajectory of queer intranational migration is rural-to-urban is untenable when the highly urbanized nature of these societies is acknowledged, and that other paths of relocation are likely to be equally important for queer people.

Further conceptual problems: linear migration and teleological identity-formation

But there is yet another notable conceptual problem embedded in these empirically derived rural–urban explanations of queer migration, one not specifically related to the demographic context of these countries: I contend that the concentration on the rural-to-urban trajectory suggests a teleological finality with respect to displacement and ontological closure with regard to identity. Most of the individual migrations described in these studies are *uni*-directional—'one way', from the country to the city, with no returns, detours or subsequent moves—suggesting a 'one-off' escape from rural constraints to the freedom and affirmation of the queer urban community.[4] And since these studies assert that the desire for freedom of sexuality figures prominently in the decision to move, this uni-directional rural-to-urban movement intimates a once-and-for-all emergence from the rural 'closet', and the assumption of an already-fully-formed and fixed urban queer identity. It is not only that the urban permits the *possibility* of 'being' queer, and migration facilitates those opportunities for self-discovery. Rather, in suggesting that symbolic rural–urban contrasts are central to coming out and configure gayness (Weston 1995), it seems that physical movement of the body and change in identity is simultaneously accomplished, achieved in one act of relocation.

More serious still is the *normalization* of this uni-directional rural-to-urban movement, *and* the associated teleological understanding of sexual self-actualization, in Binnie's (2004: 91–94) recent discussion of 'queer migration and the rural/urban binary'.[5] Moving beyond Weston's and Parker's reasonably confined focus on rural-to-urban movers, Binnie (2004: 93–94, italics added) claims that the '*predominant* movements of sexual dissidents are rural to urban to escape the constraints of rural and small town life', and further asserts, perhaps more problematically, 'that the rural/urban binary plays a key role in framing coming out narratives [and] the management of sexual identities *more generally*'.[6] He relies heavily on North American studies, especially Weston,

Rubin and Chauncey. Despite noting that the 'social, cultural, political and economic contrasts [between the rural and the urban] in a densely populated country such as the United Kingdom, or the Netherlands and Belgium are fewer than within a country such as the United States', this recognition of difference does not diminish the central role Binnie (2004: 92) attributes to rural-to-urban migration. Rather, he endorses and reinforces the argument that pre-given and reasonably fixed rural–urban contrasts, and consequent rural-to-urban relocations, are largely critical to the formation of queer identities, even if the meaning of 'rural' shifts between North America and Europe.

At the same time Binnie attempts to complexify the rural–urban framework of queer migration by pointing to Raimondo's (2003) discussion of the *urban-to-rural* migration of HIV-positive gay men in the USA. But despite reversing the path of displacement, Binnie's discussion of Raimondo's study maintains the contrast between the urban the rural:

> One of the dominant narratives Raimondo examines is that of the gay man with AIDS returning home from the big city to die. She calls this the 'coming home to die' narrative. Urban life enabled these men to come out and be openly gay, something they felt unable to be in the rural heartland. (2004: 92)

Here, the urban still functions as a queer homeland, while the rural heartland continues to refuse queer identities—a denial manifested both prior to migration (gay men could not come out in the country) *and* upon return. The men are returning to the rural heartland as 'AIDS victims', not as gay men; they are migrating to finalize their lives, not discover and enact their sexual identities. And with respect to entrenching linear migration narratives, what could be more teleological than 'coming home to die'?

Consequently, Binnie's (2004: 90) discussion normalizes earlier empirically derived rural–urban conceptualizations of queer migration: he asserts that the 'most common' scale of queer migration 'is rural to urban within the same country' to escape the heteronormative restrictions of rural society. This thinking generates several problems, discussed above, and summarized here. Queers appear to migrate only *between* the rural and the urban; other trajectories of relocation are silenced. Moreover, there seems to be an assumption that moving from the country to the city is a one-off event which facilitates coming out, suggesting a teleological and ontological finality with respect to relocation and identity-formation. This is contrary to current ideas of fluid, contingent identities, failing to adequately acknowledge that 'coming out is not once-and-for-all' (Sinfield 2000: 103), and is also incongruent with the realities of those queers who might engage in peripatetic migrations, moving back and forth between cities, between regions, and between the urban and the rural. For instance, the initial move from the country to the city may be the first leg of an ongoing migratory journey, where further relocation to other cities or regions—or even return migration—could be in part informed by sexuality and be linked to an *ongoing* process of coming out. Consequently, normalized rural–urban explanations occlude the potential diversity and complexity of queer migration and associated sexual self-actualization.

Rethinking queer migration: embodied queer identity quests

Much of the problem, I suggest, lies in the *scale* at which queer migration has been considered in historical, empirical and theoretical work. In focusing on rural-to-urban

movement on a *national* or *regional* scale, researchers have downplayed (e.g. Weston, Parker) or overlooked (e.g. Binnie) the various trajectories followed by queer migrants (especially in highly urbanized countries), often using the rural–urban framework to explain such movements as basically akin to rural-to-urban migration. Hence, to try to get at and understand the diversity of queer migration, I suggest we need to shift explanatory power from the rural-to-urban scale of displacement and fixed rural–urban contrasts, to the motivations of individual migrants and the movement of the queer body itself through space. We need to 'downsize' the scale of explanation from the regional or the national to the *body*. In doing this, we need to keep our sights on sexuality itself as a key motivating factor, which should enable us to recognize diverse paths of migration *without* privileging one trajectory at the expense of others. To this end, I propose that queer migration should be understood as *an embodied search for sexual identity*—an *individual search* which can be *materialized at differing, multiple scales and paths of relocation*.

The starting point for rethinking queer migration, then, should be the motivations underpinning the decision to migrate. Weston's, Cant's and Parker's discussions demonstrate significant similarity in the factors precipitating migration in widely differing economic and cultural contexts, suggesting that sexuality-related motivations always figure in queer migration. In Brazil, for instance, Parker demonstrates that while education, employment and financial opportunities contribute to the decision to migrate, these are *not* independent of sexuality-related reasons. Weston, in the USA, and Cant, in the UK, convey remarkably congruent findings. All three studies consequently demonstrate that queer subjects often move in order to 'come out of the closet' and freely enact queer identities and same-sex desires. They seek identity-affirming places and environments where they can find like others, a queer community and a sense of belonging—as Binnie (1997: 240) says elsewhere, queer subjects migrate 'to find a queer home'. There is a key relationship here between displacement and queer identities: queer migrant subjects move out in order to come out (Fortier 2001). In other words, migration is often informed by a yearning to discover, explore and enact sexual identities and desires. Thus, according to Brown:

> A quite recurrent theme in these [coming out] narratives was that of having to move to another place in order to know oneself as gay. It wasn't enough to just open the closet door; one had to leave its interior for a different location. (2000: 48)

Or, as Kuntsman (2003: 300) succinctly expresses it, 'my coming out story *is* the story of my immigration'.

Queer identity quests: embodying and diversifying displacement

How can we use this recognition that sexual identity-affirmation often underpins migration to explain the *diversity* of queer displacements? The idea of relocating to come out adumbrates Knopp's (2004) recent discussion of the importance of identity quests for queer subjects' detachments from and attachments to (different) place(s). I want to draw critically on Knopp here, employing, but reworking and extending, his ideas in order to help rethink present understandings of queer migration. Quests for identity are '*personal journeys* through space and time—material, psychic and at a variety of scales—that are constructed

internally as being about the search for an integrated wholeness as individual humans living in some kind of community' (Knopp 2004: 122–123).[7] These identity quests attain a common psychic purpose and material outcome for queer subjects. Psychically, the quest is a search for wholeness, for physical, emotional and ontological security amidst a heterosexist world that disciplines (and often oppresses) queer identities and behaviours. And this psychic quest is geographically realized as spatial displacement, as a search for 'people, places, relationships and ways of being' that bring a sense of order and security to a fractured identity enmeshed in often-hostile power structures (Knopp 2004: 123). The quest for identity, then, is predicated on migration. Moreover, the *personal*, *individualistic* nature of the journey draws attention to the displacement of the queer body *itself*, to the *movement of embodied subjects themselves* through space as they search for different sexuality-affirming contexts. In this way, the queer identity quest can be seen as a way of *embodying* sexuality-related displacement, and thus 'downsizing' the explanatory scale of queer migration from the regional and national to the *body*.

Using this understanding of the queer identity quest, we can begin to recognize the *diversity* of actual queer migrations. The personal and embodied nature of quests for identity means that this common experience of displacement is grounded *differently* for individual queer subjects, so that material journeys through space and time occur on a *variety* of scales and paths. And while not evoking notions of embodiment *per se*, Knopp does draw attention to the diverse patterns of migration that are produced by individual quests for identity:

> *At the more individual level* a good example is the widespread practice of distancing from families and communities of origin in order to 'come out'. … Story after story and study after study features people who are either rejected by or voluntarily disavow their roots and then *move* … in order to 'find themselves' (or, more modestly, simply to protect themselves). Frequently this entails traveling great physical distances over long periods of time, and/or reinventing our everyday lived spaces and their meanings. … It is … about testing, exploring, and experimenting with alternative ways of *being*, in contexts that are unencumbered by the expectations of tight-knit family, kinship, or community relationships—no matter how accepting these might be perceived to be. *Hence, rural to urban migrations of gay men, for example, are particularly common. But so are international, interregional and intraurban migrations and movements, as well as a general embracing of cosmopolitanism*. (Knopp 2004: 123, initial and final italics added)

Thus, the embodied nature of these queer quests for identity generates variety and versatility in the midst of a common queer experience: the concept looks to personal, individual experiences of displacement, and understands that these are materially realized in a variety of scales, from the intraurban to the international. In short, by drawing attention to the movement of the queer body itself, and to the identity-related aspirations underpinning such displacement, the idea of the 'embodied queer identity quest' can accommodate and account for multiple paths and scales of queer migration.

Extending embodied displacement: peripatetic migrations

It is through these embodied identity quests that we can also begin to understand that *peripatetic* migrations may be more important

to some queer subjects than singular relocations from the country to the city. Knopp (2004: 124) asks us to consider 'the attachment that many ... queer people feel to movement itself', intimating that this has been underemphasized in accounts of queer migration. This affection for movement is particularly resonant with—perhaps central to—the embodied queer identity quest. Knopp (2004: 129) contends that '[q]ueers are actively engaged in processes of personal reinvention that intrinsically entail examinations of ourselves and our surroundings', and thus are keenly aware of the contingent nature of personal identities and places. Hence, queers often develop a strong affection for placelessness/movement over place/emplacement. If we contemplate queer migration in light of this attachment to movement, it seems likely that for more than a few queer migrants final identity-fixing emplacement may not be as important as the quest itself. Indeed, Knopp (2004) suggests that ontological and emotional security can be found in movement itself.

But we also need to interrogate how this attachment to movement works *in practice*. Certainly, it seems plausible that some forms of mobility—such as leisure travel or 'cruising'—are eroticized by queer subjects precisely because of their fluidity, uncertainty and liminality, and the opportunities for alternative modes of sexual(ized) performativity and interactivity thus generated (Turner 2003; Waitt and Markwell 2006). In this sense, there is affection for mobility *in itself*. However, I want to suggest that attachment to movement is not only affection for the experience of moving *per se*, but is also predicated on an understanding that place does *not* provide ontological closure. Rather than affection for mobility in and of itself, attachment to movement simultaneously signifies a need queer people often feel to find *somewhere*—some *place*—to explore alternative ways of being, *at the same time* recognizing that this search is *ongoing*, generating *movement between places*. In other words, the search for sexuality-affirming *places* remains important, but this can only be realized through accepting that *multiple sites* may need to be experienced and 'tested', and so continuing *movement* is often inevitable.

I would suggest, then, that affection for mobility co-exists with desire for (temporary) emplacement, and that this perspective on attachment to movement might be particularly pertinent for understanding queer migration (as a particular form of queer mobility). For instance, Fortier (2001: 414), in her examination of 'home' in 'narratives of queer migration', similarly reasons 'against a linear conception of migration', contending that some narratives reveal queer migration to be a 'story ... of multiple movement between homes—of flights, detours, returns—and of multiple encounters with estrangement and familiarity experienced in different locales'. She contemplates each locale as a site of attachment where one can momentarily ground one's identity in an ontological and material process of becoming. And since *multiple* sites of attachment are embedded along a migratory path, at each new site one has the opportunity to develop greater self-understanding, and to work on sexual identity and desire. In this way, migration becomes the spatialization of an *ongoing* process of coming out, where each site of attachment along a migratory path momentarily grounds who one is, or was, in this process of becoming.

This discussion points to the potentially crucial significance of *peripatetic*, *non-linear* paths of migration which have been silenced in rural–urban frameworks of queer migration. I believe that this recognition is critical for rethinking queer migration: such multi-directional, meandering migrations of

embodied subjects most tellingly, most clearly, counter the teleology of rural-to-urban models, strongly suggesting that queer migration cannot in all cases be explained as once-and-for-all exile from a rural closet to a queer urban homeland. Rather, peripatetic displacements suggest that queer migration is sometimes a continuing search for sexual identity, an ongoing journey of self-discovery, where each site of attachment is a material context to work on embodied identity and desire—typically selected for its potential to engender exploration and interactivity, and thus nurture sexuality—and final emplacement is deferred for some time. Peripatetic migrants make detours and returns, criss-crossing between the rural and urban, moving from city to city, region to region, deferring—sometimes refusing—settlement in a queer urban community. (This refusal of the urban is palpably demonstrated through a growing body of work on queer ruralities, including Bell and Valentine (1995), Valentine (1997), Phillips, Watt and Shuttleton (2000), Bell (2003) and Smith and Holt (2005)). These meandering, progressive relocations disrupt the easy determinism of normalized rural–urban conceptualizations of queer migration, drawing attention to what is absent from, and what cannot be explained by, such frameworks. In place of these limited rural–urban frameworks, I suggest that a focus on *embodied displacement* can elicit the diverse, multi-directional and highly individualistic movements which appear to often underpin personal quests for queer identity.

Further thoughts on embodied relocation: desire and displacement

So far I have considered how understandings of queer migration might be rescaled, reworked and enhanced through focusing on the *movement* of the body through space, as if the body was simply another *scale* of inquiry. But the body is much more than this. As the site of personal identity, it is through the body that we encounter and make sense of the world. The body is the threshold between individual selves, the lens through which we perceive the intentions and actions of others, and the medium through which we engage in interpersonal interactions and relationships. Consequently, interrogating the *qualities of embodiment* can also extend our understanding of queer migration as an identity quest—especially given that *sex*uality is experienced *through* the body. To this end, I here provide a more sustained inquiry into the possible links between *bodily sexual desires* and displacement—particularly peripatetic displacements.

Queer identities, as I define them in this paper, are wrapped up with embodied experiences of same-sex desires.[8] Or, as Maddison (2002) frankly asserts, coming out involves 'getting laid'. Consequently, it seems untenable to separate queer identities from the embodied practices of same-sex intimacies, and I suggest that the quest for queer identity can be seen at the same time, then, as a quest to explore new practices of sexual pleasure, to satisfy the curiosity to *experience* same-sex desires.[9] If the queer identity quest is about testing and experimenting with new ways of being in unencumbered contexts, then key to this is exploring alternative bodily desires, the way bodies of the same sex might come together and provide mutual pleasure.

In this context, queer migration might be seen as a very visceral search *for bodies* with which to explore and experience these sexual pleasures. Binnie, for instance, informs us:

> 'I had desires about places and people *before* I ever had a chance to realize them. I had always dreamed

of the city as the space where these desires would be materialized' (2001: 108, italics added).

Sexual desire, then, can help to shape the contours of queer migration. Desire precedes and underpins actual physical intimacy, and can consequently motivate relocation and determine the trajectory of displacement; as Maddison (2002: 157) bluntly puts it, 'the small-town boy … moves to the big city … to get laid'. And while Binnie sought the fulfilment of these desires, the quest for other bodies, in the city, others have found erotic satisfaction in rural areas. Bell and Valentine (1995), for instance, bring our attention to those lesbians and gay men who actively choose to move to the countryside, often to create same-sex communes and alternative lifestyles (also Bell 2003; Valentine 1997). Obviously, sexual desire is not the only basis for the existence of rural communes—they are fully functioning communities seeking to break with certain undesirable elements of modern life. But in establishing same-sex communities, and in deliberately eschewing the 'oppressive' rules of heteronormative society, these rural communities also provide fertile environments for sexual experimentation.

Of course, this still seems quite teleological—either the urban meets the visceral need for bodies and pleasure or, for those shunning urbanity for a more 'natural' life, rural communities fulfil same-sex desires. But I want to suggest that a consideration of sexual desire can also point towards a more complex, less teleological, more fluid understanding of queer migration. Contemplating Deleuze and Guattari's (1972) reworking of desire is helpful here. Against a psychoanalytic approach which imagines desire as contained and constrained by Oedipal anxiety, they conceptualize desire as 'energy, a positive source for new beginnings, and a "voyage of discovery"' (Brown 2000: 129). In this way, desire is not something to be contained or fulfilled, but is in itself productive, generative and creative. Instead of imagining desire which flows in only one direction, Deleuze and Guattari celebrate the multiplicity of desire—desire as 'schizophrenic'—a condition that refuses to conform to pre-given structures and assumptions.

If we, in turn, *embody* this schizophrenic desire, then embodied desire can be seen as multiple, fluid and everchanging—it is never fully formed, and never really fulfilled. As a creative source of new beginnings, there can be no closure on sexual desire felt through the body; the visceral fulfillment of erotic pleasure is always temporary. Monogamous commitment notwithstanding, then, an individual's desire to experience certain bodies for sexual pleasure may change, moving from body to body—even more than one body at a time. And as sexual desire shifts and flows, our bodies flow along with it. In so doing it can shape personal geographies and migrations—especially for queers, who stand outside pre-given structures of (heteronormative) desire from the moment they begin to desire other bodies. In this way the quality and experience of sexual desire itself can militate *against* the linearity and teleology of rural-to-urban migration, and underpin a more peripatetic path of ongoing relocation. Each site of attachment becomes a context for experimenting with and exploring sexual desires, and each relocation can be, to a greater or lesser extent, informed by the quest for new bodies and new pleasures.

This is, in turn, complicated by those queer migrants who *resist* desire, and who seek to *avoid* embodied sexual experiences for various reasons. For instance, this self-identified gay man, Lance, relocated to a tiny, remote community, Jabiru, in Australia's Northern Territory, with no other same-sex-attracted

men (of which he is aware), in order to evade sexual intimacy:

> I suppose ever since HIV broke out of Africa, the experience [of sex with other men] is now far and in between. I suppose that's why I live in Jabiru now. … Are we destined to end up with HIV? I suppose I'd be the first one to say that I'm not really into rubbers [condoms]. And living in Jabiru is really good, because then you don't have to worry about using rubbers because there's nothing out there to use rubbers on. So you end up going to bed with Mrs Palm and her five daughters anyway. Moving out to Jabiru was a good move. (Hodge 1993: 84)

Clearly, a phobia about HIV/AIDS informed Lance's decision, but this fear is unquestionably intertwined with the practice of sexual desire. Instead of changing his sexual practices to incorporate condom-usage, Lance would rather avoid intimacy with other bodies, turning instead to auto-erotic practices to satisfy sexual urges and pleasures. This further complicates the links between desire and displacement, demonstrating that the evasion of sexual practices, just like the need to experiment with embodied pleasures, can inform the trajectories of queer migration.

Sexual desire, then, is not only an untrammelled flow, as Deleuze and Guattari suggest—it ebbs as well, and this adds another dimension to the diverse and complex spatial outcomes of desire. Teleological models of queer identity development assert that one moves through stages of denial and self-questioning, before self-acceptance and the generation of a mature, 'out' queer identity (Plummer 1995). But as Lance shows, sexual identity-formation is *not* in all instances a linear journey to be 'out' and to *freely practise* same-sex desire. Sexual desire is *not* intransigent, and Lance's choice to not engage in intimate sexual acts, and to relocate in order to avoid such encounters, revealingly contributes to our understanding of queer identity quests. His decision, it seems to me, does not constitute a return to the 'closet', but rather a reworking of the bodily contours and practices of sexual desire and queer identity.[10] Moreover, it reveals that the *mutability of bodily desire*—its *ebbing and flowing*, working together, but pulling in different directions—can crucially shape the spatial expressions of queer identity quests in interesting ways, generating unexpected relocations, like Lance's move to a remote township. Rural–urban conceptualizations of queer migration, with their teleological underpinnings, would be hard-pressed to explain such a move. In this way, Lance demonstrates another way in which the embodied experiences and desires of actual migrants militate against the linearity and determinism of rural-to-urban explanations of queer migration, and point to more peripatetic and less predictable patterns of displacement.

Extending work on queer migration

In eschewing rural-to-urban models of queer migration, and instead focusing on the movement of queer bodies through space, this conceptual paper provides a more capacious understanding which can account for the diverse and multiple displacements of queer subjects. By 'downsizing' the scale of inquiry, and offering a new explanatory framework centred on the *spatial outcomes* of *embodied* identities and desires, I seek to extend research on queer migration, and encourage further contemplation and investigation of the apparently common relocations of queer subjects. In doing so, this discussion begins to make innovative, productive linkages between cultural, queer and

population geographies. Consequently, in concluding this piece I wish to suggest some further conceptual and empirical directions for work on queer migration, specifically, and on the interpenetration of sexuality and space more broadly.

Clearly, more empirical work is needed. In recent years most work on queer migration has been theoretical, focusing on diasporic constructions of queer subjects through displacement (Fortier 2001, 2002; Sinfield 2000; Sugg 2003). While this work is important in showing the relations between queer subjectivities, homes, homelands and national identities, it is time to return to the 'field' and try to understand how and why actual queer subjects migrate. To further unravel narratives of queer migration we need to engage in dialogue with the migrants themselves, asking them deeper questions about the relationship between queer identities and relocation. At this stage of research, the 'nuts and bolts' of queer migration are still largely unexplored, and the idea that 'nonnormative sexuality is often tantamount to spatial displacement' is still arguably anecdotal. One important purpose of my admittedly theoretical musings here is to suggest some fruitful directions for future grounded work on queer migration.

And in taking up further empirical work, new conceptual understandings will also be required. In this conceptual piece I have only *begun* to hint at the diversity of relocations elided by rural–urban frameworks of queer migration. In pursuing these diverse displacements, we may find it necessary to rethink the very 'meaning' of migration with regard to queer people. For instance, the technical meaning of migration precludes *intra-city* movements, instead referring specifically to regional, national and international scales of displacement. But a focus on embodied displacement may reveal that *shorter* relocations, even between suburbs within cities, might be as important to queer people embarking on identity quests. For example, through interviewing thirty-seven gay/lesbian Australians about their homemaking practices for my doctoral research, I found that many had moved *within* the city of their birth, from the family home to nearby suburbs, specifically to come out and explore their sexuality (Gorman-Murray 2006a). Hence, moving out to come out may not necessarily entail migrating over great distances, moving between cities—simply leaving the parental home and relocating elsewhere in the same city could be ontologically very significant for young queers, and comprise the beginnings of a queer identity quest.

More recognition and exploration of the intersection of embodied desire and spatial displacement is also needed here. Desire is largely overlooked as a generative factor of relocation, both in literature on queer migration and in migration research more generally, with a focus largely on economic, employment and familial (both positive and negative) reasons. Even where 'lifestyle' issues are important—as in the 'sea change' phenomenon—desire is unconsidered (Burnley and Murphy 2004).[11] But a focus on *embodied* displacement—even in terms of the limited examples presented here—suggests that sexual desire can influence relocation in interesting ways. And this is perhaps all the more important for individuals defined by their *sex*uality, who often have to migrate in search of like others and sexual freedom. Consequently, this paper urges more contemplation—and empirical investigation—of the links between desire and displacement for sexual dissidents. At a basic level, for instance, both queer and heterosexual migrants might move to find or be with a partner, and desire is

certainly implicated in such relocation decisions.

Finally, this (re)conceptualization has implications beyond queer migration itself, also contributing to new ways of thinking about queer subjectivity and the relationship between sexuality and space more broadly. Rather than seeing 'gay identity [as] first and foremost an urban identity' (Binnie 2004: 91), I argue for the recognition of individual agency in the constitution of queer identities. Acknowledging that 'subjectivity is … highly contextual and spatially contingent' (Knopp and Brown 2003: 412, 422), resistance to heteronormativity and the consequent constitution of queer identities happens in both urban and regional places, in big cities and tiny villages, and everywhere in between. At the same time we must remain sensitive to the nuanced relationship between space and sexuality, between place and identity, recognizing that queer subjectivities often take different forms in larger and smaller cities and regional towns. It is these spatial differences that still need to be teased out and understood. In what ways might urban and regional queer identities be constituted differently? How might spaces be used differently? Indeed, which spaces—especially given the absence of visible queer commercial venues in non-metropolitan localities? Might virtual spaces—the internet—become more important? These questions, *inter alia*, need to be addressed to develop a more explicit understanding of the difference that (urban and rural) space makes in the constitution of sexual identities.

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Notes

1 While there is a growing body of literature on queer *international* migration (Binnie 1997, 2004; Stychin 2000; Valentine 1996), I will not investigate this work. The issues involved in international migration—such as legal factors—are perhaps somewhat different to those of intranational movements.

2 According to national statistical data, the percentage of the population resident in urban areas is 89 per cent in the UK (2001 census), 81 per cent in Brazil (2000 census) and 80 per cent in the USA (2000 census). At the same time I do recognize differences in the three countries' historical experience of urbanization. While the urbanization of the USA and the UK gathered pace during the nineteenth century, Brazil's demographic change is a post-Second World War phenomenon. *Nevertheless*, Brazil was already a predominately urban society when Parker began his anthropological study of gay communities in 1989, with over 70 per cent of the population resident in cities during the 1980s, and 76 per cent by the early 1990s.

3 This is suggested, for instance, in the empirical work conducted for my doctoral project on gay/lesbian homemaking in Australia (Gorman-Murray 2006a). I analysed forty-six autobiographical narratives written by queer Australians, and interviewed thirty-seven gay men and lesbians. I found that most were city-born, and if they had 'moved home', had done so between (or within) cities. While generalizations cannot be drawn from this qualitative data, the prominence of urban-to-urban movement in these narratives is nevertheless suggestive of the wider significance of this trajectory of queer migration.

4 Cant (1997) does indicate a couple of exceptions—Spike Pittsberg and Gregg Blachford—who embark on multiple migrations. But these non-linear migrations are international, not intranational.

5 Simultaneously, I want to acknowledge that this is perhaps the one seriously problematic assertion in

Binnie's *The Globalization of Sexuality* (2004), which is an otherwise powerful and important polemic on the spatiality of queer subjectivity. As I stressed in a recent review, his book introduces and extends key arguments about how national and class differences intersect with sexuality in globalizing processes (Gorman-Murray 2006b). I therefore want to emphasize that my issue with Binnie's discussion here is narrowly focused on his troubling assertions regarding queer intranational migration, and not with the book as a whole.

6 Maddison (2002) likewise argues that the interweaving of self-realization and rural-to-urban migration is normalized as the 'standard narrative' of 'gay autobiography' in Britain.

7 To be certain, such displacements are common for many with class, gender and/or race privilege in individualistic societies, but as Knopp (2004: 124) indicates, 'their connections to a rather urgent need to reinvent the self shine through particularly strongly in many, many accounts of gay and lesbian lives' (see e.g. Cant 1997).

8 I recognize that sexuality is a complicated discursive construct, not only a matter of sexual practices (indeed, as the preceding argument suggests). But here I want to seriously consider the materiality of embodiment, especially the way the imperatives of the physical body itself might affect queer migration. I also acknowledge that queer identity does not preclude opposite-sex-attraction.

9 Johnston (2005) points out that when the body is considered academically, it is usually in the realm of ideas, not as a messy, passionate, desiring agent. But in this instance, the rationality of embodiment (personal identity) cannot be separated from bodily passions (sexual pleasures).

10 Especially given he is 'out' in a published autobiographical narrative.

11 The 'sea change' (sometimes 'tree change') phenomenon in Australia refers to the recent movement of significant numbers of people from metropolitan centres to regional (often coastal) localities in search of environmental amenity and community cohesion (Burnley and Murphy 2004).

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Abstract translations

Repenser la migration queer au travers du corps

Les discussions portant sur la migration intranationale de dissidents sexuels ont mis l'accent plus particulièrement sur les mouvements allant du rural vers l'urbain, et ont conceptualisé la «migration queer» pour l'essentiel à partir du couple symbolique rural/urbain. Les déplacements du rural vers l'urbain ont ainsi été normalisés tout en élidant la vraisemblable diversité propre aux changements de milieux queer. On y retrouve également l'idée de la normalisation des récits narratifs sur le changement d'un milieu rural vers un milieu urbain, laquelle comprend une finalité téléologique et ontologique

laissant à entendre qu'il est possible de sortir à jamais du « placard » rural. Pour rendre les choses encore plus complexes, je propose de réduire l'échelle utilisée pour expliquer la migration queer d'une opposition immuable rurale/urbaine à un mouvement réel du corps queer à travers l'espace. À cet effet, je revois la «migration queer» comme une «quête identitaire queer incarnée», proposant que si envisager une «sortie du placard» est généralement le fondement de la prise de décisions de changer de milieu, la nature personnelle, incarnée et individuelle de cette expérience engendre des mouvements sur une diversité de sentiers et d'échelles. Dans une certaine mesure, ce sont les migrations péripathétiques qui, de manière révélatrice, s'opposent aux modèles téléologiques du rural vers l'urbain. Par ailleurs, en faisant ressortir que les déplacements incarnés reposent sur une «sortie du placard», j'envisage les affects potentiels liés aux désirs sexuels physiques dans la détermination de la forme que prend la migration queer.

Mots-clefs: migration queer, couple rural/urbain, corps/incarnation, sortir du placard, quête identitaire, migration péripathétique, désir sexuel.

Reconsiderando la migración queer a través del cuerpo

Debates sobre la migración intranacional de disidentes sexuales suelen tratar el movimiento del campo a la ciudad y, en gran parte, conceptualizan la 'migración queer' por un binario simbólico campo/ciudad, lo cual normaliza el desplazamiento del campo a la ciudad mientras elide la verdadera diversidad del traslado queer. También hay un fuerte indicio de definidad teleológica y ontológica en la normalización de las narrativas de traslados campo-ciudad, lo cual insinúa una 'de una vez por todas' salida del 'closet' rural. Para obtener una mayor complejidad, sugiero que se debería reducir la escala explicativa de la migración queer, de los contrastes fijos campo/ciudad, al actual movimiento del cuerpo queer por el espacio. Con este fin yo reconsidero la 'migración queer' como una 'búsqueda de identidad queer encarnada' y sugiero que, aunque el 'destape' muchas veces sustenta la decisión de trasladarse, la naturaleza personal, encarnada e individualista de esta experiencia genera movimiento por una variedad de caminos y a varias escalas. Posiblemente las más importantes entre éstas son las migraciones peripatéticas que, eficazmente, refutan la teleología del modelo campo-ciudad. Además, al evocar los desplazamientos encarnados que se puede atribuir al 'destape', trato de contemplar los posibles afectos que los deseos sexuales corporales tienen en moldear los contornos de la migración queer.

Palabras claves: migración queer, binario campo/-ciudad, cuerpo/encarnación, destape, búsquesda de identidad, migración peripatética, deseo sexual.